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Certifications for Security Consulting

When working as a security consultant, certifications, as mentioned earlier, help enhance your understanding of niche security concepts. The more common ones are Certified Protection Professional (CPP) and Physical Security Professional (PSP) from ASIS International, and the GIAC Security Expert (GSE).

Name	URL
Advanced Information Security Certification	www.securityuniversity.com/certification.php
Certified Protection Professional	www.asisonline.org/certification/cpp/index.xml
Check Point Certified Managed Security Expert	www.checkpoint.com/services/education/certification/certifications/ccmse.html
Check Point Certified Security Expert	www.checkpoint.com/services/education/certification/certifications/ccse.html
Check Point Certified Security Expert Plus	www.checkpoint.com/services/education/certification/certifications/ccse_plus.html
GIAC Security Expert	www.giac.org/track_cert.php
IBM Certified Advanced Deployment Professional (Tivoli Security Mgmt)	www-1.ibm.com/certify/certs/tvadse03.shtml
Information Systems Security Architecture Professional (CISSP Concentration)	www.isc2.org/cgi-bin/content.cgi?page=8#cat06
Information Systems Security Engineering Professional (CISSP Concentration)	www.isc2.org/cgi-bin/content.cgi?page=8#cat06
Information Systems Security Management Professional (CISSP Concentration)	www.isc2.org/cgi-bin/content.cgi?page=8#cat06
Physical Security Professional	www.asisonline.org/certification/psp/pspabout.xml

Ethical Hacker (CEH) program, CHFI (Computer Hacking Forensic Investigator), and LPT (Licensed Penetration testing) programmes certify individuals in the network security discipline of Ethical Hacking from a vendor-neutral perspective.

Brownie Points

Candidates with hands-on experience of installing, maintaining, and troubleshooting security issues on a domain are sought after. However, no-one will get you to manage their security if you don't have any experience! To get around this all-too-common problem, you could begin by networking computers and setting up security policies on the domain in an NGO or small organisation for free; after all, it's the experience that counts. That apart, one needs to develop deep expertise in one specific area of security to get further. Experienced candidates with industry certifications are given first preference. Soft skills are a must at any level. Leadership skills, presentation skills, and such also come in handy, especially in consulting.

Advice For Freshers

Since the industry believes in hiring experienced candidates for higher positions, it is important to gather certifications and gain hands-on experience before trying to edge your way into the industry. Most candidates get placed via campus recruitments; in such a scenario, when you show experience—as in part-time jobs or self-undertaken projects and such—you have a better chance of getting through than your colleagues.

According to Sanjay Katkar, CTO, Quick Heal Technologies Pvt Ltd, “The challenge in recruitment is to find good developers and researchers. Most of the candidates we see are well-prepared

for the job of application developer or a similar position. Candidates with an interest in system-level programming, or those willing to work on reverse engineering, those who have an interest in assembly programming / debugging, are scarce. Another challenge is keeping up-to-date with the latest trends and the newer kinds of attacks / malware.”

All fresh recruits undergo an induction and training program, the duration of which varies from company to company. “Most employees change jobs frequently so as to get as much experience as they can on various domains and security setups,” says a security industry official who does not wish to be named.

Money Matters

Remuneration offered to fresh recruits is between 1 to 2 lakh per annum. It is an unofficial rule of thumb that salary increases by a lakh with every added year of experience. Salaries may take longer to go up in the product-led approach we spoke about earlier.

Remuneration in the consulting-led approach depends on the certifications you have under your belt and the number of years you have served in the industry. A security consultant with four to five years of coding experience and one to two years of consulting experience can expect between 10 and 12 lakh per annum.

When you reach the pedestal of the specialist-led approach—with at least 14+ years of experience—salaries can cross 20 lakh per annum.

The security industry is at the cusp of an explosion in India. Though it takes longer to be promoted to higher positions than in most industries, salary increments are at par with the best. Earning more and more certifications is the key to getting better job opportunities here. ■

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